




**"WE LOOKED AT THE ROOT CAUSE OF ISSUES.... EVENTUALLY, WE WANT A MAINTENANCE PRACTICE LIKE JAPAN HAS FOR ITS HIGH-SPEED TRAINS"**

**ASHWINI VAISHNAW,** *Railways minister*

be much for the world's fourth largest railway system that carries 25 million passengers every day, but the Vande Bharat passengers represent a different class of travellers. They pay premium money to travel in India's fastest and most expensive trains (which cost Rs 130 crore apiece, almost double the price of a conventional train in India).

Passengers said the seemingly plush seats were not comfortable enough. The toilets were persistently wet, the air-conditioning often felt inadequate... the list kept getting longer. Passenger feedback and grievances started proliferating on social media, on the official 'Rail Madad' complaints platform and in conversations with onboard railway officials.

External factors, too, made the Vande Bharat's journey rather eventful. That uniquely Indian problem—cattle straying on to tracks, particularly in Gujarat and Rajasthan—played havoc on punctuality. Another problem was stone-pelting—the Vande Bharat got hit roughly 283 times between 2019 and 2023, leaving its sleek black windows shattered. Now, with nine new Vande Bharat trains added to the line-up this month, Indian Railways is striving to iron out most of the "passenger pain points".

## NEW PRACTICES

"'Mission Zero Complaints' is our way of striving for a higher benchmark of service for the Vande Bharat, through better maintenance practice, more cleanliness etc.," railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw tells INDIA TODAY. "Eventually, we are aiming for a main-